RESEARCH, PRODUCT & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT DIVISION / DOCUMENT V03

Bank Customer Discovery, Willingness-to-Pay & Commercial Sponsorship Validation Protocol

Research design • falsifiable customer evidence • pricing and sponsor qualification • independent gate review

Version 1.0 | 19 October 2026 | Evidence cut-off: 19 October 2026 | Classification: Confidential - proposed research instrument

Status: Draft for management and Legal/CISO review. Not an authorised bank outreach or validated commercial result.

Executive management position

V03 will decide whether the proposed PSS Acceptance 360 service solves an important bank-owned problem at a price, scale and contractual allocation of responsibility that PSS can sustainably deliver. The first hypothesis is Option B: PSS Operate + Connect. V03 must test Options A, C, D and E without a predetermined winner. Bank interviews have NOT yet been performed; all readiness and pricing findings remain unverified.

Management question	V03 decision rule
Does a paying buyer exist?	Require named bank economic buyer, purchasing process, budget source, substitute product and written commercial follow-up—not verbal enthusiasm.
What will bank buy?	Specify actual workflows and measurable service levels for Operate/Connect, or demonstrate why Pay-led/partner/no-build wins.
What price is defensible?	Use disclosed current costs, economic value and counterfactual alternatives; anonymous indicative statements are not signed willingness to pay.
When can PSS proceed?	V03 informs commercial feasibility only; no live payment, bank data transfer, binding contract or platform spend authorised here.

1 Mandate, authority, dependencies and exclusions

- Sponsor: PSS Research, Product & Business Development (RPB&D). Reviewers: CFO/Finance, Legal/Compliance, Technology, Risk/CISO and at least one independent reviewer without sales incentives.
- Prerequisites: written management authorisation for external outreach; bank-approved contact list; suitable confidentiality notice; interview and information-handling approval; no transmission of protected bank/customer records without a separate authorised process.
- Upstream dependencies: S02 is a pre-validation choice screen, and S03 is a public-evidence current-state gap assessment, not an internal architecture audit. S04/V01 establishes programme controls.
- Exclusions: no representation that PSS has product, settlement, scheme, QR or SoftPOS approvals beyond original documentation; no claim that respondent views bind a bank; no commitments of rate, exclusivity, project spend or production support.

2 Research questions and pre-registered hypotheses

ID	Testable proposition	Disconfirming evidence
V03-H01	Banks incur identifiable merchant reconciliation, exception or servicing costs.	Buyers cannot quantify persistent problem or demonstrate relevant incidents.
V03-H02	A bank would buy PSS Operate + Connect instead of its existing solution.	Bank keeps current supplier/in-house operation with equal or superior value.
V03-H03	An accountable budget owner can sponsor an executable procurement path.	No authority, allocation or credible budget path.
V03-H04	Bank-sponsoring minimum fee plus usage charging can be commercially acceptable.	All buyers reject minimums at amounts supported by CFO cost-to-serve.
V03-H05	Value can be measured in cashable cost avoidance, fewer exceptions or incremental revenue.	Benefits are vague, unmeasurable or non-attributable.
V03-H06	Bank data and operational workflows can be used under legal role boundaries.	Bank prohibits essential records, integration or outsourcing model.
V03-H07	A PSS Pay-led offering is or is not a more attractive first product.	Pay-led proves superior buyer commitment, device fit and incremental economics.

ID	Testable proposition	Disconfirming evidence
V03-H08	A vendor-partner model is or is not cheaper on comparable obligations.	Vendor quotes/rights deliver lower life-cycle total cost and risk.
V03-H09	At least one bank is willing to sign a non-binding, detailed pilot exploration record.	Qualified buyers decline even conditional written engagement.
V03-H10	Non-shareholder bank buyers can access services on fair commercial terms.	Governance, eligibility or exclusivity constraints block fair access.
V03-H11	Bank savings survive net costs of integration, migration, support and governance.	Whole-life bank ROI is non-positive or dominated by BAU.
V03-H12	The potential buyer can specify measurable service KPIs and accept objective evaluation.	No owner will validate baselines or approve measurable service criteria.

3 Study population and recruitment

Recruit an initial purposive sample of approximately 4–6 banks, including shareholder and non-shareholder institutions where permitted. Seek diversity in acquiring maturity, merchant base, geography, payment channel and existing provider architecture. A small, purposive sample is for discovery, not a statistically representative estimate of total addressable demand.

Target participant	Role in evidence	Minimum field record
Economic buyer / retail or digital banking executive	Owns commercial outcome and can sponsor spend	Buying authority, business objectives, budget source, procurement next steps
Merchant acquiring / channels owner	Owns merchant operating flows	Activity baseline, exception burden, current service provider
Operations / reconciliation owner	Verifies workflow pain and achievable savings	Incident sample and process steps; no sensitive records in interview
Technology / procurement	Validates delivery and sourcing alternatives	Dependencies, existing contracts, change effort
Finance and Risk/Compliance bank counterparts	Independently challenge ROI and outsourcing rules	Savings categories and permission constraints

Respondent unit is a bank, not an individual executive. Interview several roles per bank where possible; do not count multiple employees of one institution as multiple buyers. Maintain a decliner/nonresponse log to prevent survivorship bias. Pre-set a minimum of four eligible banks for initial synthesis; inability to recruit is itself an outcome requiring scope review.

4 Interview controls and bias prevention

1. Obtain sponsor authorisation and confirm the bank's preferred confidentiality and note-taking practice. Do not record audio without explicit permission.
2. Use an unaided current-state interview before presenting any PSS product concept. Elicit real recent exceptions and measurable process costs before asking interest questions.
3. Present alternatives B, C, D and E in rotated order, and A as an optional full-platform proposition; make the no-new-build option explicit.
4. Avoid leading adjectives, invented benefit numbers, implied NBE approvals, and assumptions that PSS already has an implemented feature.
5. Ask respondents to name their existing alternative, decision owner, procurement steps, budget and basis for any pricing view.
6. Do not rank banks by personal connections or shareholder status. Separate research team, sales team and independent reviewer.
7. Send respondent-approved factual summaries and tag each statement as observed, bank-reported, estimated, conditional or not supplied.

5 Structured research modules

Module	Core questions	Output
M1 — Bank profile	Segment, merchant acquiring strategy, deployed providers and payment instruments	Bank-level profile and recruitment stratum
M2 — Job-to-be-done	Recent incidents, reconciliation issues, dispute delays, manual work and escalation	Pain map, quantified cases where permitted
M3 — Current alternative	Internal build, gateway, bank partner, switch and vendor; contractual	Counterfactual baseline and

Module	Core questions	Output
	expiry and switching friction	vendor dependency
M4 — Concepts	Test Operate+Connect, Pay-led, partner-led and BAU; add full suite last	Ranked service preference with reasons
M5 — Outcome value	ETB/person-hours saved, transaction error reduction, active-merchant uplift, risk effects	Bank benefit/value tree with evidence
M6 — Commercial terms	Current budgets, acceptable price architecture, minimum commitments, SLA remedies	Range of defensible bank-paid prices
M7 — Sponsor conversion	Authority, conditions, timetable for detailed scope/term sheet, document request	Buyer qualification and next action

6 Willingness-to-pay protocol: avoid false validation

Pricing is tested only after unaided current-spend and alternative discovery. Obtain an unprompted monetary value or maximum affordable annual cost first. Then show package/pricing configurations using ranges prepared and signed off in advance by Finance from actual cost-to-serve and legally permissible revenue channels. Do NOT invent a tariff to anchor buyer responses.

Pricing dimension	Candidate contract form	Buyer question and validation
Implementation	One-time non-recurring ETB fee	What integration/migration work is bank prepared to fund and through which capex/opex approvals?
Availability and operating readiness	Monthly minimum or tiered subscription	Which service commitments justify a fixed monthly cost; would it be budgeted before merchant activation?
Usage	ETB per active merchant and/or eligible settled transaction	What event is billable? How are failed, duplicate, reversed and offline items excluded?
Operations / evidence premium	Exception management, reconciliation and bank reporting tier	Can bank quantify incremental cost reductions and accept outcome-linked SLA?
Change controls	New adapters and regulatory change requests	What is included in base fee versus approved change order?

Use a buyer-validated price interval as directional evidence only. A pricing survey, Gabor–Granger choice, or stated intent cannot replace a finance-reviewed commercial term sheet. Flag hypothetical bias. Avoid collecting merchant/customer identifiable transaction detail; accept bank-approved aggregates and redacted workflow examples.

7 Buyer readiness and evidence ladder

Level	Evidence description	Allowed interpretation
L0 — Unknown	No interview / no eligible authorised respondent	No demand evidence
L1 — Pain described	Recent operational problem from responsible owner	Problem hypothesis plausible
L2 — Value scoped	Baseline, alternative and quantified value with owner confirmation	Solution value being validated
L3 — Commercially qualified	Economic buyer, budget route, price architecture, procurement timing and written follow-up	Credible purchasing opportunity, not a sale
L4 — Written conditional sponsor	Bank-authorised non-binding scope + indicative price/conditions + data-use dependencies	Sponsor interest documented; still not a contract
L5 — Signed binding procurement	Executed definitive contract under institutional approvals	Commercial commitment, subject to its clauses

Gate recommendation cannot classify a bank as L4 merely because an individual signs an interview sheet; Legal must validate the signatory's authority and the document's legal status. Even L4 remains non-binding. Any L5 status is outside V03 research authority and requires separate formal approvals.

8 Bank-level value and two-sided unit economics

Model element	Calculation / verification rule
Bank annual baseline	Current internal labour + third-party charges + risk/exception costs + allocated relevant fixed costs; avoid double count.
Bank annual measurable benefit	Avoidable cash costs + verified net incremental margin + risk reduction if appropriately evidenced; confidence-adjust.
Bank programme cost	Implementation + bank-specific integration + fixed fee + variable fees + oversight and transition expense.
Bank investment benefit	Incremental measured benefit minus bank programme cost; break down by actual cash

Model element	Calculation / verification rule
	and non-cash benefits.
PSS contract contribution	Bank contracted net receipts minus incremental platform, rail, vendor, support, security, and bank-adapter costs.
Non-financial impact	Merchant complaints, resolution time, coverage, settlement transparency, accessibility; not booked as cash revenue.
Comparators	Same scope, time frame and assumptions for B/C/D/E and full platform A.

9 Data, confidentiality and security

- Interview data: use respondent codes, role and organisation only where necessary, and controlled-access storage. Collect individual names/contact details separately from coded analytical workbook.
- Obtain prior bank consent and Legal/CISO approval for confidential business information. Do not ask for personal customer records, card PAN, CVV, PIN, credentials, account identifiers or raw transactions in a discovery interview.
- Any later aggregate extracts or sandbox testing require written data-sharing permissions, purpose limitation, access and retention rules, permitted location and deletion controls; protect business-confidential data.
- Ethiopia's Personal Data Protection Proclamation No. 1321/2024 is in force; Legal must determine its application to proposed activities and the parties' actual obligations.
- Disclosure to external vendors or presentation to committees requires authorised redaction; client-facing summaries must not reveal another bank's data or negotiated prices.

10 Research output and QA criteria

Deliverable	Acceptance evidence
V03a — Coded bank interview archive	Completed approved forms, dates, respondent roles, consent status and independent second-reader checks.
V03b — Bank pain and alternative analysis	Current baseline, counterfactual, competing supplier, confidence grade and contradictory observations.
V03c — Pricing and WTP findings	Unaided price and CFO-prepared choice test, bank authority, price architecture and explicit nonbinding status.
V03d — Sponsor pipeline and conditions	Named accountable sponsor, non-binding term-sheet stage, follow-up dates and legal permissions.
V03e — Executive synthesis	Bank-by-bank coded evidence, comparative B/C/D/E outcome, reasons for re-ranking S02, limits and formal gate recommendation.

11 Gate rules and exception triggers

Before the fieldwork starts, RPB&D, Finance and Risk should approve commercial thresholds and disconfirming evidence tests. The current protocol does not invent numeric purchasing/ROI criteria without actual bank cost and PSS economic data. Proposed minimum evidence for an affirmative V03 recommendation is: at least one L4 conditional sponsor at a contract configuration Finance judges potentially sustainable, independent confirmation of bank value, documented competing option and a clear legal path for subsequent evidence requests. This is necessary but not sufficient to approve live pilot or platform spend.

- STOP or narrow: no eligible bank economic buyer can confirm any valuable unmet problem; price ceilings systematically fall below validated PSS variable/fixed-cost allocation.
- REVIEW / re-scope: a PSS Pay-led or partner solution outranks Operate+Connect using observed willingness and comparative life-cycle economics.
- HOLD: legal/regulatory responsibilities, access permissions, current certifications or operational assets cannot be evidenced.
- DO NOT aggregate unrelated interview sentiments into a fake market percentage; show counts, dissenting banks and a sample-limit statement.

12 Workplan and responsibilities

Stage	Target sequence	Owner and gate
Protocol sign-off	Before outreach	RPB&D; CFO for pricing; Legal/CISO for information handling

Stage	Target sequence	Owner and gate
Buyer list and recruitment	Weeks 1–2	RPB&D, CEO shareholder-bank liaison where authorised
Discovery and unaided baseline	Weeks 2–4	Research interviewer plus independent note reviewer
Concept and pricing interviews	Weeks 3–6	Research + Finance observer, rotated concepts
Written follow-up and sponsor terms	Weeks 5–7	BD, bank economic buyer, Legal
Independent challenge and findings	Weeks 7–8	Finance, Risk, Legal, Technology; ExCo gate pack

The timetable is indicative and does not imply permission to contact banks. Missing permissions or unavailable bank personnel should be reported as blockers rather than described as completed interviews.

13 Roles, review independence and reporting

Function	Responsibility
RPB&D	Design instruments, recruit fair sample, run interviews, code evidence and prepare synthesis.
Finance / CFO	Approve price test inputs, independently validate bank economics and PSS contribution; resolve price/benefit inconsistencies.
Legal / Compliance	Approve confidentiality script, permissible data intake, bank letters, authority and contract conditions.
Technology / Operations	Corroborate feasible service promises and actual processing and integration capabilities.
Risk / CISO	Review data-security, operational outsourcing and evidence-handling risk; record dissent.
Executive sponsor	Approve outreach authority and resource envelope; cannot convert a research note into a contract.

14 Sources, provenance and exclusions

ID	Source / status	Relevance
INT-S02	PSS Acceptance 360 S02 Strategic Options Assessment v1 (18 Oct 2026) — prior draft	Alternative set A–E, initial Option B hypothesis; not buyer validation.
INT-S03	S03 Current-State Capability and Gap Assessment v1 (18 Oct 2026) — prior draft	Defines unverified operating/certification gaps.
INT-TOR	S04/V01 Master Research, Validation and Feasibility TOR v1 — prior draft	Mandate boundaries, stage gates and study design.
EXT-01	NBE, Draft National Digital Payments Strategy 2026–2030, https://nbe.gov.et/ndps/	Policy orientation; remains visibly labelled DRAFT at cut-off.
EXT-02	NBE public operators register, https://nbe.gov.et/payment-instrument-issuers-system-operators/	Public licence list; not a substitute for PSS original licence terms.
EXT-03	CGAP, Acquiring Models (2019), https://www.cgap.org/research/publication/acquiring-models	Distinguish processing and merchant servicing acquisition models.
EXT-04	CGAP, Choosing a Profit Strategy (2019), https://www.cgap.org/research/publication/choosing-profit-strategy-for-merchant-payments	Price and network-effect trade-offs; contextual, not Ethiopian bank evidence.
EXT-05	Ministry of Justice, Proclamation 1321/2024, https://justice.gov.et/en/law/personal-data-protection-proclamation/	Privacy legal framework; requires institution-specific interpretation.
EXT-06	PCI SSC, MPoC https://www.pcisecuritystandards.org/standards/mobile-payments-on-cots-mpoc/	Standards context for the Pay-led comparator.
EXT-07	EthSwitch FY25/26 results, https://ethswitch.com/2026/10/13/ethswitch-closes-fy-2025-26-with-strong-growth-etb-2-6-billion-in-gross-profit-before-tax/	Network scale contextual reference, not PSS purchasing evidence.

Source cut-off is the date on the cover. If later data revise this design, log the change and preserve the earlier version. Internal and external evidence are deliberately not interchangeable.

15 Management recommendation and requested validation authority

Management should approve V03 as a research design, authorise outreach only after Legal/Risk sign-off and assign Finance to own all monetary assumptions. RPB&D should return with an evidence-graded bank-level report, a validated or rejected primary offer and an independent commercial gate conclusion. No platform procurement, bank contract execution or live payment activation is requested.

Approval / review	Name / date / comments
RPB&D lead — prepared	_____
CFO — pricing protocol	_____
Legal / Compliance — external engagement	_____
CISO / Risk — data handling and challenge	_____
CEO / delegated sponsor — outreach authority	_____

15.1 Controlled decision record

Decision required	Status / approval conditions
Approve bank discovery protocol	Proposed / not yet approved. Legal, CISO and CFO review required before outreach.
Authorise specific bank contacts	Pending CEO/delegated sign-off and bank-contact compliance checks.
Authorise confidential bank information	Not granted here. Separate data permissions and appropriate agreements required.
Agree commercial falsification criteria	CFO/Risk must register price floor, benchmark and stop conditions before interviews.
Record alternative-option protection	C, D and E remain eligible to supersede B where evidence supports.
Authorise live pilot or investment	NOT REQUESTED and not conferred by V03 approval.

15.2 Dissent and unresolved-evidence record

Reviewer / function	Unresolved issue, owner, proposed resolution date
Finance	_____
Technology / Operations	_____
Legal / Compliance	_____
Risk / CISO	_____

No signature block above should be interpreted as signed until the responsible officer physically or digitally signs an authorised record. A management draft does not authorise outreach by itself.